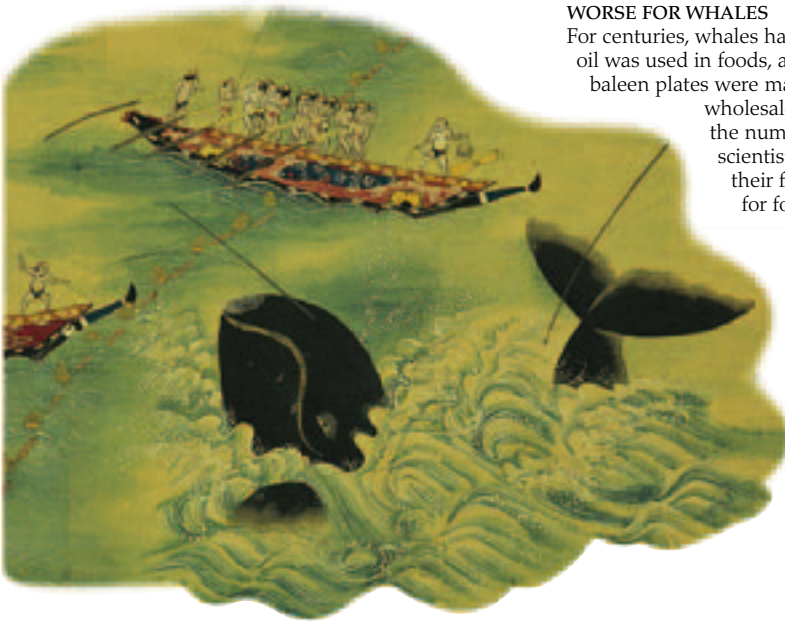


WORSE FOR WHALES

For centuries, whales have been hunted for their meat, oil, and bones. Whale oil was used in foods, as lubricants, and in soap and candles, and the broad baleen plates were made into household items such as brushes. The wholesale slaughter by commercial whalers drastically reduced the number of whales. Now most whales are protected, but scientists doubt whether some populations will ever recover their former numbers. Some kinds of whales are still caught for food, mainly by local people.



Japanese painting showing early whalers in small boats risking their lives in pursuit of whales



Oily whale meat extract used to make margarine

Ground-up whale meal used in animal feed and pet food

Whale liver oil was a source of vitamin A

Sperm oil was a high-grade lubricant for motors and cars

Engraved nautilus shell

Intricate floral pattern cut into shell



Sponges settled on scrap iron in a Red Sea harbor

TAKE CARE

A basket sponge this size may be 100 years old, but could be damaged in an instant by a diver's thoughtless kick. Many kinds of sea life are more fragile than they look. Corals can be killed if touched by divers. All kinds of junk end up on the seabed (center right) and can smother marine life. Air pollution can also affect sea life. During the 1997–98 El Niño, sea temperatures rose by 2–4°F (1–2°C) in many parts of the Indian Ocean, causing some corals to eject their algae partners and die. Many scientists suspect global warming may have contributed to the unusual temperature rise.

